

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 1/8: 1. Three-question method

RELIGIOUS EXPERIENCE

- 1 PHENOMENOLOGY: what is it like?
- 2 OBJECT: what is experienced – God, the Holy, Brahman, emptiness, unity?
- 3 INTERPRETATION: how does a tradition name and frame the seeming?
- 4 EPISTEMIC FORCE: does seeming-to-encounter justify belief?

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TYPES: mystical unity | numinous encounter | conversion | prayer/worship
| revelatory vision | non-dual awareness

CONTROL: intensity and sincerity establish occurrence, not automatically veridical object.

JAMES'S MARKS OF MYSTICAL EXPERIENCE

INEFFABILITY: cannot be adequately stated

NOETIC QUALITY: felt as insight or knowledge

TRANSCIENCY: usually brief

PASSIVITY: received rather than fully produced by will

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“fruits, not roots”: assess transformation in life, not only origin theory

authority is strongest for experiencer, not coercively binding on outsiders

plural experiences support openness, but diverse objects complicate doctrinal proof.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 3/8: 3. Rudolf Otto and the numinous

THE NUMINOUS = MYSTERIUM TREMENDUM ET FASCINANS

mysterium: wholly other, beyond ordinary grasp

tremendum: awe, majesty, creature-feeling, dread

fascinans: attraction, grace, compelling value

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“Holy” includes non-rational numinous depth plus moral/rational development

SACRED != automatically God: an object, place or event may mediate the Holy

objection: description can reify culturally trained emotion into an external object.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 4/8: 4. Advaita and Radhakrishnan

ADVAITA: aparokṣānubhūti is immediate knowledge of non-dual Brahman
not subject seeing divine object; subject-object division is sublated
śravaṇa -> manana -> nididhyāsana -> liberating knowledge

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RADHAKRISHNAN: integral intuition discloses spiritual unity and grounds tolerance
strength: experience is transformative and non-inferential
pressure: ineffability vs doctrinal description; private certainty vs public adjudication;
Advaita interpretation may be one conceptual construction among religious traditions.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 5/8: 5. Object models

MODEL	WHAT EXPERIENCE PRESENTS
personal theism	an addressive “Thou,” grace, command, presence
Otto	numinous Holy / wholly other
Advaita	non-dual Brahman; no final subject-object split
Buddhism	Dharma/cessation insight without a personal creator
naturalism	altered brain/body state interpreted religiously

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SAME phenomenological report may underdetermine ontology;
object-claim needs interpretation beyond raw immediacy.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 6/8: 6. Veridicality tests

SWINBURNE PRINCIPLE OF CREDULITY: accept seeming appearance unless defeated

PRINCIPLE OF TESTIMONY: generally trust reports unless there is reason not to

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DEFEATERS: drugs/pathology | contradiction | prior implausibility | unreliable setting

positive checks: coherence | moral fruit | intersubjective fit | predictive/explanatory value

ALSTON: socially established doxastic practice may confer prima facie justification

objection: incompatible religious practices cannot all validate exclusive objects unchanged.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 7/8: 7. Criticisms, replies and public life

FREUD: wish-fulfilment | MARX: social consolation | neuroscience: neural correlate
pluralism: contradictory interpretations | ineffability: no communicable evidence
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replies: causal explanation does not equal debunking; all perception has neural correlates;
fruits and disciplined practices may distinguish mature experience from fantasy
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prayer/worship test object-relations: petition, gratitude, surrender, contemplation
public use must be modest: experience may justify commitment without authorising coercion.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 8/8: 8. PYQ answer spine

DEFINE type -> describe phenomenology with James/Otto -> specify claimed object
-> distinguish experience from interpretation -> apply credulity/testimony and defeaters
-> compare Advaita/theism/Buddhism -> strongest naturalist or pluralist objection
-> reply -> qualified public verdict

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CLOSE: religious experience is significant evidence within a life and practice,
but its object is not read straight off the feeling; interpretation and defeater control remain.